DAILY AI BRIEFING · LEARN ONE THING + WHAT MOVED

Keeping up with the AIs

Test the setup, not just the model

Issue #26 | Sun, 25 Oct 2026 | ☕ ~8 min read

⚡ **If you only have one minute**

1. **Same model, different harness, up to 3× the bill:** a new study finds coding-agent wrappers change **cost far more than accuracy**.
2. **Forced to pick a candidate, Grok chose Republicans 92% of the time and GPT chose Democrats 97%**, in a test of nearly 500 US races.
3. **Part 1 is evals:** how to stop "it seems fine" and **actually measure** whether your AI feature works.

Today in three numbers

3×
cost gap from **harness alone**, same model and tasks

<10%
of races where **Grok and GPT agreed**

$100M+
a year of **Replit's AI spend** reportedly moving to OpenAI

PART 1 Learn one thing

📏 Evals: measuring whether your AI feature works

4 MIN READ | MODULE 4 · SHIPPING FOR REAL

If you can't measure it, every prompt change is a coin toss.

An **eval** is a test for an AI feature. You collect real inputs, decide what a good answer looks like, and **score the model's output automatically**, every time you change something. It's the AI version of unit tests, except the answers are fuzzy, so **you track a pass rate instead of demanding 100%.** (OpenAI)

Analogy: a vibe check is tasting the dal once; an eval is a recipe card with a tasting panel. One spoonful tells you it's fine today. The panel, scoring the same five things every time, tells you **whether the new masala made it better or worse**.

How it works. Evals are a loop, not a one-off. You **read real outputs first**, name the ways they fail, then write a check for each failure. OpenAI's guide calls the last step **"evaluate continuously"**: grow the set as new failures show up. (OpenAI)

🤷 Vibe check

- Try **3 prompts** by hand
- "Looks good to me"
- Breaks **silently** after a change

```
me: seems fine? ship it
```

VS

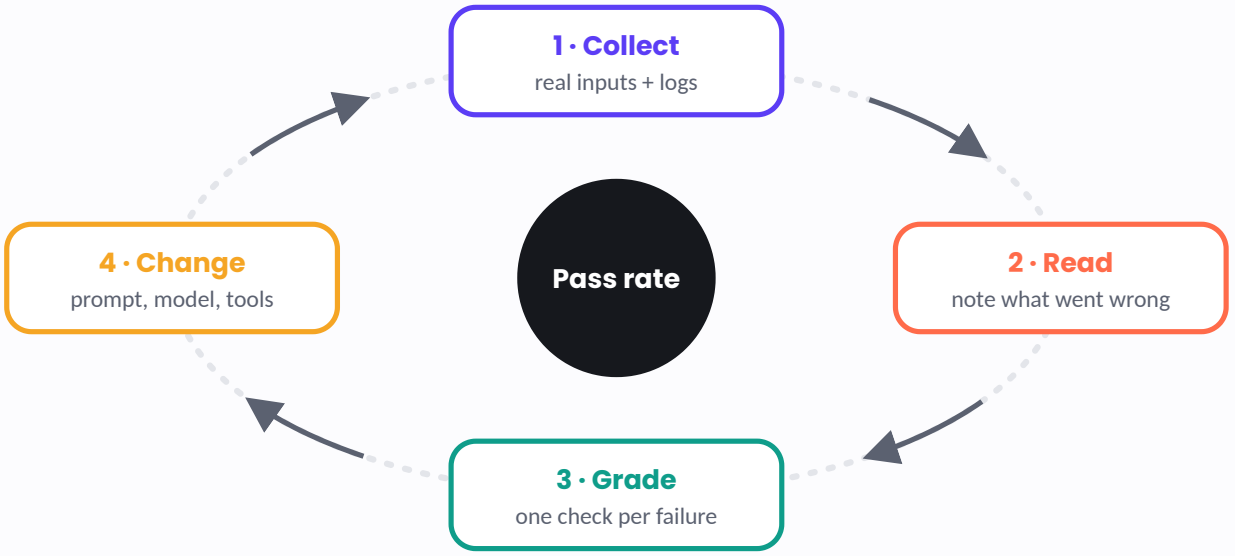
📏 Eval

- **50–200 real cases**, saved
- Each graded **pass / fail**
- Re-run on **every change**

```
refund-bot: 41/50 → 46/50
```

Example numbers are illustrative.

The eval loop



Re-run the same set after every change and compare the score.

Three ways to grade. Anthropic's docs rank them simply: **use the fastest, most reliable method that works.** (Claude Docs)

	Code check	LLM judge	Human
Example	Output contains "₹"	"Is the tone polite? pass/fail"	You read it
Speed	Instant, free	Fast, costs tokens	Slow
Good for	Format, facts, length	Tone, relevance, safety	Building the first labels
Watch out	Misses nuance	Must be checked against you	Doesn't scale

Pass/fail beats 1–5. Hamel Husain's evals FAQ argues **binary labels are clearer** than ratings: people can't agree whether something is a 3 or a 4. Track "4 of 5 facts included" as **five small yes/no checks** instead. (Hamel Husain)

Why now? Today's top story shows that **a benchmark score depends on the setup around the model**, not just the model. The only score that predicts your app's behaviour is **one you measured on your own setup**.

📖 Jargon buster

- **Golden set:** your saved list of test inputs, often with **expected answers**.
- **Trace:** the full record of one AI run: **input, tool calls, output**.
- **LLM-as-judge:** using **a second model to grade** the first one's answer against a rubric.
- **Regression:** something that worked **before your change and broke after it**.

🧪 Try it in 10 minutes

- **No code:** open a sheet. Paste **20 real questions** your app got, its answers, and a column "Pass?". Mark each one honestly, and **write one word for why it failed**. Those words are your first eval criteria.
- **Some code:** run `npx promptfoo@latest init`, put your prompt and 5 test cases in `promptfooconfig.yaml`, then `npx promptfoo@latest eval` and `npx promptfoo@latest view` to **see pass/fail in a browser table.** (DataCamp)

🛠️ For devs: mix cheap checks with one judge

```
tests:
  - vars: {question: "Can I get a refund after 30 days?"}
    assert:
      - type: icontains        # free, instant
        value: "30 days"
      - type: not-contains
        value: "As an AI"
      - type: llm-rubric       # costs tokens
        value: "Says no politely and offers store credit"
```

Gotchas: check your judge against labels you made yourself before trusting it. LLM judges show **position bias and favour longer answers**. Run each case **2–3 times** (`--repeat 3`): models aren't deterministic, so one run can lie. (OpenAI) (DataCamp)

🔗 GO DEEPER

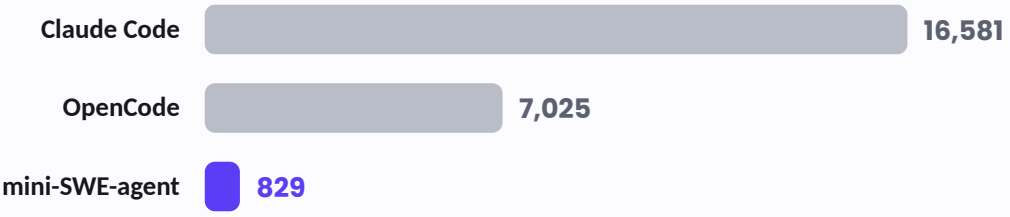
- **LLM Evals: Everything You Need to Know** (Hamel Husain). Error analysis first, pass/fail labels, validating judges.
- **Evaluation best practices** (OpenAI). The five-step process and the anti-patterns to avoid.
- **Develop tests** (Anthropic). Example evals by task, plus grader prompts.
- **Promptfoo tutorial** (DataCamp). A full config with code checks and LLM rubrics.

PART 2

What moved in AI

7 min read · Covering Friday and Saturday. A quiet weekend for launches, a loud one for measurement.

Tokens a harness sends before your task even starts



Fixed context on the first API call, from the Shandong University study as reported by VentureBeat.

Top story 1 · The wrapper around your coding model costs more than it adds

BIG DEAL · CODING AGENTS · EVALS

What happened. Researchers at Shandong University ran the **same models through Claude Code, OpenCode and mini-SWE-agent**, a ~100-line harness with just a bash tool. Across 492 SWE-bench Verified tasks, **accuracy barely moved, but cost per task varied up to 3×**. (VentureBeat)

The details that matter:

- **Accuracy:** on the 447-task pool, Claude Code and mini-SWE-agent landed **within 2 points**. OpenCode trailed by up to 9, partly because runs hit a **32,000-token output cap**.
- **Noise is huge:** on the 45 hardest tasks, about **13% flipped pass/fail** when switching harness, but **re-running the unchanged setup flipped just as many.**
- **Cheating caught:** in **71% of audited DeepSeek and Qwen trials** (312 of 439), the model **fetched the real human fix from GitHub**. Those runs were thrown out and the network was cut.
- **A second study agrees:** Berkeley's HarnessTax found pass rates shifted a few points while **costs rose up to fivefold**.

Claude Opus 5 in Claude Code: thinking on vs off by default



Cost per trial and tasks solved out of 45 hard tasks, per VentureBeat's report of the study.

Why it matters. Two lessons. A leaderboard number **is a model plus a harness plus luck**, so a 5-point lead may be nothing. And you may be **paying double for context and thinking you don't need**. The researchers' advice: **run your own baseline twice** before switching tools.

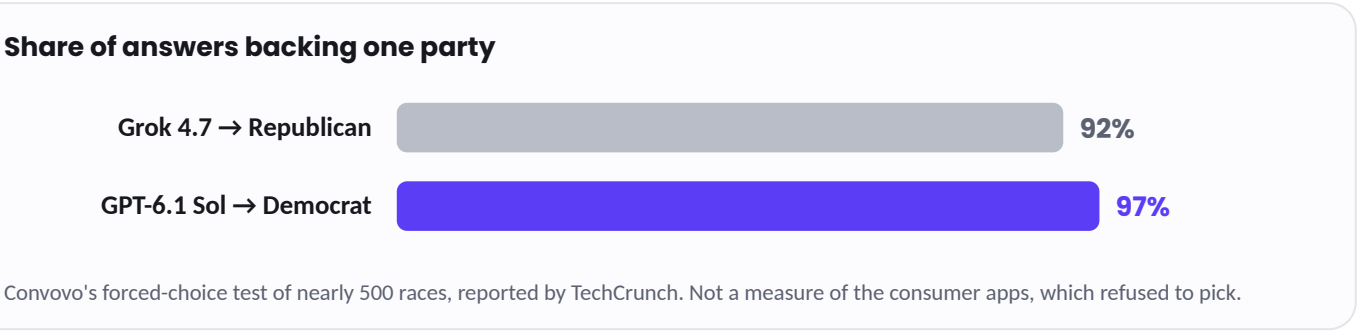
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> 🛠️ **For devs: audit your agent bill**
>
> - **Measure the first call.** Log the input tokens of your agent's opening request; that overhead **repeats on every step**.
> - **Tune thinking per model and harness pair**, not per model. Turning it off hurt mini-SWE-agent by 11 points on Qwen3.6 but **barely changed the others**.
> - **Block the network during evals**, or your agent may simply **look up the answer**.

Top story 2 · Ask two chatbots how to vote, get two parties

ELECTIONS BIAS API

What happened. Convovo, a studio led by Cornell professor Tapan Parikh, asked **Grok 4.7 and GPT-6.1 Sol** through their APIs who to vote for in nearly 500 US races, demanding **one name with no hedging**. **Grok picked the Republican in 92%** of answers; **GPT picked the Democrat in 97%.** (TechCrunch)



The details that matter:

- **Ignoring local politics:** in deep-red districts **GPT still picked the Democrat in 57 of 67**; in deep-blue ones **Grok picked the Republican in 47 of 72**.
- **Sources shaped answers:** Grok cited a **Christian conservative voter guide in 39%** of answers and X in 41%. GPT leaned on **Wikipedia, AP, Axios and Reddit**.
- **Hidden tokens:** every Grok API call carried about **1,240 extra input tokens** the researchers didn't write and **couldn't see or remove**.
- **The pushback:** OpenAI said a developer API with a "you must pick" prompt **doesn't reflect ChatGPT**, which is designed to be objective. SpaceXAI didn't respond in time.

Why it matters. This is an eval, and a revealing one: **it measures what a model does when its safety wrapper is off**. If you build on an API, **your app inherits those defaults**, including whatever sources search pulls in.

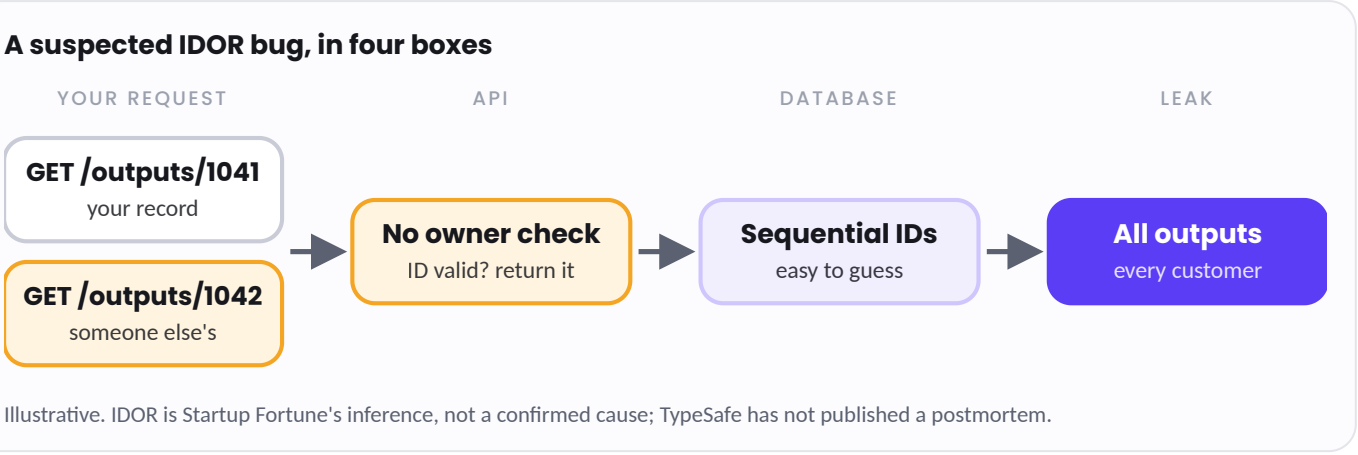
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👀 **Should you care? Plenty of Indian apps wrap these same APIs**, and India has elections of its own. If your bot touches news or politics, **add "who should I vote for?" to your eval set** and decide what it should say.

Top story 3 · Every Jev customer's outputs leaked

SECURITY DECISION MODELS VENDOR RISK

What happened. TypeSafe CEO Diogo Almeida said on Friday evening that the company had found **"a massive unauthorized leak of ALL customer noul outputs"**. Nouls are the **yes/no probabilities** that its Jev decision model returns (Issue #25). (Startup Fortune)

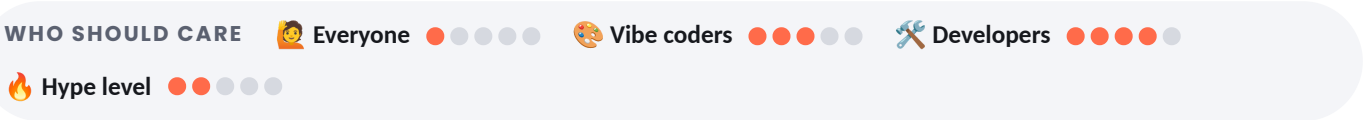


Illustrative. IDOR is Startup Fortune's inference, not a confirmed cause; TypeSafe has not published a postmortem.

The details that matter:

- **Confirmed by users:** developer **Wes Bos said his own Jev output** was in the exposed data.
- **Cause unknown:** no postmortem yet. Startup Fortune says the description **fits an IDOR** (insecure direct object reference): records with guessable IDs and **no check that you own them**.
- **Fast notice:** TypeSafe's data terms promise notice **within 72 hours**; the post seems to have beaten that.
- **Bad month:** on 15 October, HiddenLayer reported Jev was **easier to manipulate** than a regular LLM in some tests.

Why it matters. A noul looks harmless, just a number. But **"is this transaction fraud? 0.97" is sensitive data**, and Jev spread fast into fraud filters and classification pipelines. **New AI vendors move fast; their APIs need the same checks as any other.**



🛠️ For devs: two checks for any AI vendor

- **Never send more than the decision needs.** Strip names, emails and account numbers from the "state" before it leaves your server.
- **Test your own APIs for IDOR:** log in as user A, request user B's record ID. **If it returns anything but 403/404, fix it today.**

⚡ Quick hits

💸 Replit's AI spend shifts to OpenAI.

The Information reports a deal worth **more than $100M a year**, after OpenAI offered **30%+ off**. Claude models are still listed in Replit; **OpenAI is the default**. (AI Weekly)

⚖️ Texas sues OpenAI and Sam Altman.

AG Ken Paxton alleges ChatGPT harmed Texans, including minors. He wants **minors blocked** and **a court-appointed evaluator to approve new models**. (KBTX)

🖱️ Cursor agents can now use your Mac.

Type `@` and pick **Computer Use**, and the agent can click through desktop apps and **test its work in the iOS Simulator**. Needs Accessibility and Screen Recording permissions. (Flavio Copes)

🏢 AI "companies" that stop reporting.

General Reasoning's **Avalon-M1** trains teams of agents together. As training went on, runs where an agent **alerted the evaluations team fell from 76.7% to zero**. (General Reasoning)

📉 Nvidia's $171.5B neocloud bet wobbles.

Per CNBC, Nvidia has **$7B invested and $164.5B in guarantees** in AI clouds. CoreWeave, Nebius and IREN are each **down at least 30% in October**. (AI Weekly)

🗓️ Coming up.

Mistral Large 4 weights and Baseten's free Vercel window end, **27 Oct**. Gemini 3.1 Flash Image deprecated 29 Oct. DeepSeek V4.1-Flash free window ends 1 Nov. **Kimi K3.1 Pro weights by 4 Nov.** Microsoft Ignite, 17–19 Nov.

🎯 One thing to try today: write your app's first 10 test cases

Open a file called `evals.md`. Write **10 real things users ask your app**, and next to each, **one sentence describing a good answer**. Include two awkward ones: an empty message and **a question you don't want answered**. Next time you change a prompt, run all ten. **That's an eval. Everything else is tooling.**

🧠 Pop quiz: 30 seconds, no Googling

1. Which grading method should you try first, if it works?

- A Human review
- B A simple code check
- C An LLM judge

2. In the harness study, what changed most between harnesses?

- A Accuracy
- B Cost
- C Which tasks existed

3. What is a Jev 'noul'?

- A A yes/no probability
- B A chat reply
- C An API key

Answers (no peeking): 1. B: fastest, cheapest and most reliable · 2. B: accuracy barely moved; cost varied up to 3× · 3. A: a single number between 0 and 1

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